Alnfiai *J Wireless Com Network* (2025) 2025:68
https://doi.org/10.1186/s13638-025-02497-2

EURASIP Journal on Wireless Communications and Networking

RESEARCH Open Access

AI-powered cyber resilience: a reinforcement learning approach for automated threat hunting in 5G networks

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Abstract

The rapid evolution of 5G networks has introduced unparalleled connectivity, speed, and efficiency. However, these advancements bring critical cybersecurity challenges due to increased attack surfaces, network slicing vulnerabilities, and adaptive threat vectors. Traditional IDS and ML-based mechanisms lack the adaptability required for real-time threat mitigation in such complex environments. To address this, we propose SecureNet-RL, an AI-powered cyber resilience model that leverages reinforcement learning (RL) for proactive, real-time threat hunting in 5G networks. The framework integrates Deep Q-Networks and Proximal Policy Optimization with federated multi-agent learning to enable distributed, adaptive defense across network slices. SecureNet-RL agents autonomously learn from network traffic patterns, identify anomalies, and mitigate threats without human intervention. The system incorporates adversarial robustness through reward shaping and GAN-generated attack simulations to counter evolving threats. Evaluated using DDoS, insider, and 0-day threat scenarios over NS3-based 5G slices, the model consistently achieves 95.8% detection accuracy, < 50 ms mitigation latency, and a false-positive rate of just 4.3%—surpassing traditional IDS (78.2%) and supervised ML (88.5%). It also demonstrates efficient resource utilization with 45% CPU and 1.5 GB memory, ensuring scalability in large-scale 5G deployments. Key contributions include: (1) real-time adaptive RL-based threat hunting, (2) federated learning integration for decentralized scalability, (3) adversarial robustness via reward and attack modeling, and (4) comprehensive validation on multi-modal threat datasets. These findings confirm that SecureNet-RL offers a scalable, intelligent, and self-improving cyber defense solution tailored for next-generation 5G networks.

Keywords: Reinforcement learning, Cyber resilience, Automated threat hunting, 5G security, Anomaly detection

1 Introduction

5G networks represent the coming of age of ultra-fast and low-latency communication, mass devices connected, real-time applications, and network slicing for dynamic resource allocation [1–3]. Although these innovations have brought about this level of innovation, they also present tremendous security risks to an adversary using complex attack surfaces and vulnerabilities found to decentralized, software defined

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infrastructures [4, 5]. In the case of 0-day exploits, polymorphic malware, adversarial machine learning attacks, etc., which are widely deployed, new generation of intrusion detection systems (IDS), and signature-based security models are not well equipped to deal with such evolving threats that attempt to evade static defense mechanisms [6, 7]. Additionally, given 5G network distributed nature as well as it requires use of multi-access edge computing (MEC) and virtualized network functions (VNFs), it is time to move beyond traditional reactive security models to proactive AI-based cybersecurity [8–10]. To address these challenges, automated threat-hunting paradigm employed artificial intelligence (AI) and RL models do detection, prediction, and mitigation of cyber threat with little human intervention [11–14].

Large-scale threat hunting in 5G networks is a feature of cyber resilience revolutionized by leveraging RL, DL, and FL to support internet of things threats discovery in an autonomous basis for detection and mitigation [15, 16]. In contrast with [17–20] methods that are based on predefined signatures, the security agents are reinforced through real-time network monitoring and adaptive decision-making. Proactive anomaly detection, which anticipates and responds to evolving cyber threats before disruption is possible, is made possible using one or several of the advanced RL techniques such as Deep Q-Networks (DQN), Proximal Policy Optimization (PPO), or Multi-Agent RL (MARL). More specifically, federated learning further improves the privacy preserving of intelligence sharing between different 5G network slices without the need to broadcast sensitive data. These AI-driven security frameworks also ensure low-latency protection, making them well-suited for mission-critical applications, such as autonomous vehicles, industrial IoT (IIoT), and remote healthcare systems [21–24]. As cyber threats become more sophisticated and adversarial, AI-powered threat-hunting systems will play a crucial role in securing next-generation 5G and 6G networks, ensuring robust cyber resilience, real-time threat mitigation, and intelligent security orchestration [25].

Despite advancements in AI-driven cybersecurity, existing RL approaches for threat hunting in 5G networks exhibit critical gaps. Current systems often rely on static reward functions and predefined attack patterns, limiting adaptability to dynamic, multi-vector threats such as adversarial evasion attacks (success rates: 80% in 6G testbeds) and 0-day exploits (missed by 70% of IDS tools) [13, 26]. Moreover, they inadequately address 5G's ultra-dense, heterogeneous architecture—such as network slicing and edge computing—which introduces scalability bottlenecks (e.g., 3.2 × higher edge compute overhead) and delays in real-time response (avg. mitigation latency > 200 ms). While datasets such as CIC-IDS-2017 and MITRE ATT and CK enable baseline RL training, they lack granularity for 5G-specific threats (e.g., slicing-targeted APTs and jamming attacks) [26–28]. Additionally, federated and multi-agent RL frameworks remain underexplored for cross-slice threat correlation, and adversarial robustness is compromised by reward poisoning (31% detection degradation). Our proposed AI-Powered Cyber Resilience model bridges these gaps by integrating dynamic reward adaptation, ensemble RL agents, and lightweight adversarial training, optimized for 5G's distributed topology to enable sub-50 ms threat mitigation while maintaining 95% + accuracy in evolving attack landscapes.

Federated reinforcement learning (FRL) is envisioned as a means of decentralized threat detection while the security enforcement of such network is optimized from a distributed aggregated 5G network slice perspective. Compared to the single-agent

learning model, the latency is reduced, the scalability is improved, and single points of failure are avoided by the multi-agent learning model. The proposed system minimizes network congestion by introducing gradient compression techniques, which keeps the AI-based security solutions lightweight and efficient.

With the aim to build an AI-powered cyber resilience framework employing RL for the automated threat hunting in 5G networks to detect anomalies in real time and proactively absorb the cyber threat.

- A reinforcement learning model modeled to autonomously adjust to the dynamic changes in the network environment that is constantly evolving under cyber threat.
- This will help in the implementation of deep learning-driven anomaly detection to detect the malicious activities with high precision and low false positives in heterogeneous 5G environments.
- Formulating an intelligent threat response mechanism that learns self how to formulate self-adaptive defense policies to mitigate risk itself.
- So as to validate the model efficacy to detect threats, response with low latency and scale for various 5G architectures.

Therefore, we propose an RL-based AI-powered cyber resilience model to incorporate 5G networks and their threats that can automate the process of hunting threats in real time, monitor them, and leverage an adaptive response. Based on the aforementioned premise, the proposed framework takes advantage of the intelligence of network security by introducing mechanisms of self-learning and self-optimizing attack patterns and defense strategies through self-improving AI.

1. *AI-Driven Adaptive Threat Hunting:* It introduces a self-learning RL-based agent that hunts itself for cyber threats in 5G networks, which is not dependent on predefined rule-based detection.
2. *Real Time and Scalable Anomaly Detection:* It provides the development of an efficient deep learning enhanced anomaly detection system, which can detect 0-day attacks and complex cyber threats with high accuracy.
3. *Autonomous Threat Mitigation and Policy Optimization:* It implements an intelligent response mechanism in order to adaptively adjust the security policy and corresponding countermeasures with the current real-time attack patterns.
4. *Extensive Performance Evaluation in 5G Environments:* Through simulation on various 5G network scenarios, the proposed model is validated to detect threats with low latency, with good scalability and adaptability.

Problem Statement: 5G networks introduce distributed architectures with low latency and high bandwidth requirements, making them vulnerable to sophisticated cyber threats such as 0-day attacks, adversarial evasion, and polymorphic malware. Traditional IDS tools and static ML-based models are ill-equipped to handle these dynamic, multi-vector threats due to their reliance on predefined rules and lack of real-time adaptability.

Motivation: There is an urgent need for an intelligent, real-time, and scalable cybersecurity framework that can autonomously detect and respond to complex threats

while preserving the performance characteristics of 5G etworks. Reinforcement Learning (RL) offers an opportunity to build self-learning agents capable of continuous policy updates without human intervention.

Contributions: This paper proposes SecureNet-RL, an RL-powered cyber resilience framework tailored for 5G. Key contributions include:

1. A novel RL-based architecture integrating DQN and PPO for adaptive threat detection.
2. Federated multi-agent learning to support scalability across 5G slices.
3. GAN-augmented training for adversarial robustness.
4. Evaluation on benchmark datasets and simulated environments, demonstrating superior performance over baseline IDS and ML models.

The remainder of the paper is structured into five sections. Introducing the challenges of cybersecurity in 5G network and the required cyber resilience support of AI coupled with the use of RL for automated threat hunting. Finally, it critically reviews all threat detection and mitigation techniques existing this day, and shows the gaps of traditional and AI-based security approaches. The Methodology presents the proposed RL-based threat-hunting framework, detailing the model architecture, training process, anomaly detection mechanisms, and adaptive threat mitigation strategies. The Results and Discussions section evaluates the performance of the proposed system through simulations, analyzing detection accuracy, response efficiency, and scalability in diverse 5G network scenarios. Finally, the Conclusion summarizes key findings, discusses the implications of AI-driven cyber resilience, and outlines future research directions for enhancing security in next-generation networks.

2 Literature review

The proliferation of 5G networks, projected to support 1.7 billion global subscriptions by 2025 [2], introduces significant security challenges due to ultra-dense connectivity (1 million devices/km^2), dynamic network slicing, and sub-1 ms latency requirements. These characteristics expand attack surfaces, with jamming attacks increasing by 34% annually in standalone 5G deployments [29], while adversarial machine learning techniques achieve 80% success rates in evading intrusion detection systems (IDS) within 6G testbeds [13]. Traditional signature-based tools fail to detect 70% of 0-day threats [26], underscoring the necessity for adaptive cybersecurity solutions. RL-driven threat hunting has emerged as a robust countermeasure, leveraging real-time adaptation to evolving attack patterns [30]. This approach integrates directly with 5G architectures, enhancing proactive defense mechanisms by dynamically adjusting security policies and optimizing resource allocation.

Modern cybersecurity operations rely on vast datasets that facilitate machine learning-based anomaly detection. Widely used datasets, such as CIC-IDS-2017, UNSW-NB15, and CSE-CIC-IDS2018, provide comprehensive benchmarks for evaluating AI-driven security mechanisms. Recent studies highlight the efficacy of behavior-based clustering and deep learning techniques in detecting sophisticated threats. For instance, Bhardwaj et al. [9] demonstrated that behavior-based clustering techniques could achieve an

F1-score of 92.1% for APT detection, while Kumar et al. [18] applied a hybrid CNN-LSTM model in vehicular networks, achieving 89.3% accuracy. Similarly, Sahoo and Upadhyay [31] evaluated scalable fair clustering methods for threat hunting in cyber-physical systems. However, static machine learning models face limitations, such as concept drift, which degrades detection performance over time. Supervised classifiers have exhibited up to a 22% decline in precision when deployed in real-world evolving threat environments [26]. Addressing this issue requires adaptable AI models capable of continuous learning, making reinforcement learning a promising direction for real-time cybersecurity adaptation.

Dynamic security policy optimization using RL has been proved to be successful in cybersecurity. In 5G honeypot environments, the performance of 5G Q-learning agents was evaluated by Radoglou-Grammatikis et al. [28], and the rate of adversarial engagement was increased by 23% above the static configurations. Timilehin [32] also integrated the Deep Q-Network (DQN) into Security Orchestration, Automation, and Response (SOAR) system and reduced incident response time by 41% in comparison with MITRE ATT and CK framework attack simulations. This reinforces RL's capability to increase cybersecurity vulnerabilities in the contexts of rapidly evolving threat scenarios.

With the evolution of the GANs in the AI-driven security mechanisms, we have integrated GANs with the RL. In particular, Brooks [10] showed that achieving 29% better attack detection rate with the models trained with adversarial scenarios from GANs particularly for detecting 0-day threats. This hybrid approach leverages attacks to boost the cyber defense with exposed RL agents to realistic simulations of attack and making them more able to adapt to newer threats.

Another area for breakthrough experience in 5G networks is strategic honeypot deployment through RL. In ultra-dense 5G environments, PPO was applied by Radoglou-Grammatikis et al. [28] to minimize honeypot resource overhead by 18 percent to achieve the same attack detection accuracy of 95%. Such approaches guarantee the efficiency to monitor large-scale deployments with minimal computation cost.

With the addition of MARL, threat mitigation in 5G network has become a powerful technique. In 5G simulations, Rapetswa and Cheng [33] showed that MARL-based spectrum sharing framework reduces by 15% response time. Based on the 5G-SimFraud dataset, this approach was validated with respect to the speed of anomaly detection and denial of service (DoS) attacks against spectral inefficiencies.

Likewise, RL-driven frameworks have assisted the security of edge computing in 5G networks. We introduce a reinforcement learning-based approach to enhancing the security of IIoT at the edge reducing false positives by 27%, while maintaining less than 10 ms response times as presented by Czeczot et al. [11]. This is a good indication of how decentralized AI models can be used to counter cyber threats in real time.

At the same time, RL has promising applications in cybersecurity, yet it faces many challenges, mainly in design of reward function and adversarial attack resilience. Adversarial reward poisoning could bring down detection rates by 31% as shown by Hoang et al. [13] and hence give an emphasis to the importance of robust reward structures. The future research should be on the adversity resilience in RL-driven security frameworks using the techniques such as meta-learning and uncertainty aware reward shaping.

In 5G security, FL is one of the privacy-preserving solutions for decentralized threat intelligence. Yazdinejad et al. [34] proposed a blockchain integrated FL model to achieve an 28% increase in the threat classification efficiency preserving data confidentiality. FL secures the models without revealing sensitive information by enabling collaborative training of the models across a number of network nodes.

Recent studies emphasize the importance of incorporating physical layer and mobility-aware features into AI-driven cybersecurity models for 5G networks. Specifically, UAV-based communication systems introduce unique mobility dynamics that affect latency, link stability, and signal propagation. Kumar and Arti [37] provide a simplified characterization of UAV communication behavior, which could be leveraged as environmental input in RL-based threat detection for mobile edge nodes. Likewise, MIMO-based transmission systems are vital to 5G, and their spatial diversity and channel behavior can inform more context-aware policy optimization. Anand et al. [36] propose a nulling-based transmission approach in massive MIMO systems, offering valuable channel state features that can enhance the sensitivity of RL agents. These insights point to future research directions where RL-based cybersecurity frameworks, such as SecureNet-RL, could be extended to consider UAV mobility and MIMO dynamics as environment variables to improve detection robustness and adaptability in real-world 5G deployments.

AI-driven security systems in 5G networks have become more complex and are what has raised concern about the interpretability and transparency of such systems. XAI frameworks are making their way as one of the essential tools to enhance cybersecurity decision-making. In a follow-up to the above, Ali and Kostakos [4] develop HuntGPT, which uses GPT-4 with anomaly detection to explain 89% accuracy in anomaly explanation within the Twitter Cyber Threat dataset. By providing human-readable explanations for detected threats, XAI enhances analyst decision-making and mitigates the risks associated with black-box AI models. As this is a key gap for future research, we propose to integrate AI-driven threat detection with XAI to make AI-driven threat detection both interpretable and adaptive.

The rapid evolution of cyber threats necessitates continuous model updates in IDS. Automated machine learning (AutoML) has emerged as a promising approach for optimizing IDS models with minimal human intervention. Yang and Shami [35] demonstrated an AutoML-driven IDS that improved F1-scores by 14% by dynamically adjusting feature selection and classification techniques based on the CSE-CIC-IDS2018 dataset. This automation ensures that security models remain effective against emerging threats while reducing the overhead required for manual tuning. The continued development of AutoML in cybersecurity is expected to enhance real-time adaptation to novel attack vectors.

The advent of quantum computing poses a significant challenge to cryptographic security in 5G networks. Traditional encryption techniques, such as RSA and ECC, are vulnerable to quantum attacks, necessitating the development of quantum-resistant security protocols. Dangi and Lalwani [12] introduced a Harris Hawks Optimization (HHO)-guided post-quantum cryptographic model for securing 5G slicing, reducing cryptographic key compromise risks by 12%. As quantum computing advances, integrating quantum-resistant cryptographic techniques into AI-driven security frameworks will be critical for safeguarding next-generation communication infrastructures.

Table 1 Comparative analysis of the previous studies

Study	Approach	Key findings	Datasets used	Challenges
Radoglou et al. [28]	Q-learning for dynamic honeypots	23% increase in adversarial engagement rates	CIC-IDS-2017	High computational overhead in real-time adaptation
Timilehin [32]	Deep Q-Networks (DQN) for SOAR	41% reduction in incident response time	MITRE ATT and CK simulations	Scalability issues in large-scale 5G deployments
Brooks [10]	RL with Generative Adversarial Networks (GANs)	29% improvement in 0-day attack detection	GAN-generated adversarial datasets	Increased adversarial sophistication
Yazdinejad et al. [34]	FL for decentralized security	28% increase in threat classification efficiency	IIoT-Malware dataset	Privacy concerns in decentralized training
Dangi and Lalwani [12]	Harris Hawks Optimization (HHO) for post-quantum security	12% reduction in cryptographic key compromise risks	5G-Slicing-2023 dataset	Quantum computing resilience implementation complexity

Table 1 provided Comparative Analysis of AI-Powered Cyber Resilience in 5G networks. This table presents the previous studies utilizing reinforcement learning and AI-driven approaches for automated threat hunting in 5G environments, comparing their methodologies, key findings, datasets, and challenges.

3 Methodology

In the proposed AI-powered cyber resilience framework, the cyber resilience is driven through RL to automating the process of threat hunting in 5G networks. This method outlines the process of developing a self-learning security model that is capable of detecting, mitigating, and adapting to the emerging cyber threats and process of evolving the software. The approach is composed of several phases of data collection, preprocessing, RL model training, anomaly detection, and real-time threat mitigation. The system captures security policies and provides scalable protection in distributed and dense 5G network environment and optimizes security policies dynamically by integrating Deep Reinforcement Learning (DRL) techniques, for low-latency response. Three subsections are then followed where the dataset selection, feature extraction, model architecture, and evaluation metrics are described.

3.1 Dataset collection

As an illustration and to train and validate the proposed RL-based cyber resilience model, we pick up some benchmark datasets in the cybersecurity field, for example, CIC-IDS-2017,[1] CSE-CIC-IDS2018,[2] and 5G-SimFraud.[3] The range offered by these datasets is quite extensive with diverse collection of real-world network traffic from DDoS attacks, other cyber threats such as insider threats and 0-day exploits among others. The traffic used in CIC-IDS-2017 is labeled for different attack scenarios, and

[1] https://www.kaggle.com/datasets/dhoogla/cicids2017.

[2] https://www.kaggle.com/datasets/dhoogla/csecicids2018.

[3] https://www.kaggle.com/datasets/humera11/5g-nidd-dataset.

Table 2 Description of the datasets used

Dataset	Year	Number of samples	Types of attacks covered
CIC-IDS-2017	2017	3.0 M +	DDoS, Brute-force, Botnet, SQL Injection, Port Scanning
CSE-CIC-IDS2018	2018	16 M +	Web-based Attacks, Insider Threats, DoS, Malware, Ransomware
5G-SimFraud	2023	5 M +	5G-Slicing Attacks, MEC-based Threats, Signaling Storms, Jamming Attacks

CSE-CIC-IDS2018 covers more sophisticated intrusion attempts. Furthermore, 5G-SimFraud targets 5G-specific vulnerabilities such as threats against network slicing and multi-access edge computing (MEC). The relevant network features are extracted by preprocessing the dataset, normalize data and filtering out unneeded information, making the resultant dataset high quality for the RL training phase.

3.2 Dataset description

Training and validation of the proposed RL-based cyber resilience model is carried out using well-known cybersecurity datasets (Table 2) such as CIC-IDS-2017, CSE-CIC-IDS2018, and 5G-SimFraud. The network traffic in these datasets consists of diverse real-world activities with normal and malicious activities. The CIC-IDS-2017 dataset created by Canadian Institute for Cybersecurity is a labeled network flow dataset simulating cyberattacks such as DDoS, brute force, SQL injection, and botnet. These attack categories are later extended to include more sophisticated intrusion attempts such as web-based exploits and insider threats using the CSE-CIC-IDS2018 dataset. Moreover, the 5G-SimFraud dataset also deals with security vulnerabilities in 5G networks such as network slicing attacks, MEC-based threats, and signaling storms. Network traffic attributes such as packet size, flow duration, source–destination pairs, etc., and their critical labels as anomaly are present in each dataset. In order to train the RL model on the datasets, they are preprocessed by eliminating inconsistencies in the datasets, normalizing numerical features, and converting the categorical attributes into a structured format in which the training can be performed. Pre-processing steps included null value elimination, categorical encoding (using label encoding), normalization using Min–Max scaling, and outlier removal based on interquartile range (IQR). Additionally, class balancing was performed using SMOTE to address data imbalance.

The datasets include network traffic attributes such as packet size, flow length, flow source–destination pairs, as well as anomaly labels. Uncountable inconsistencies are eliminated, numerical features are normalized, and categorical attributes are structured for training RL model.

3.3 Reinforcement learning model: SecureNet-RL

In view of the dynamic nature of the cyber threats in 5G networks, we develop a novel reinforcement learning-based framework of SecureNet-RL, specifically for maintaining real-time cyber resilience. Autonomously detecting, predicting, and mitigating cyber threats in dynamic network environments, SecureNet-RL is able to achieve this using yet another model: the Lie differential inclusions. A Multi-Agent Federated Reinforcement

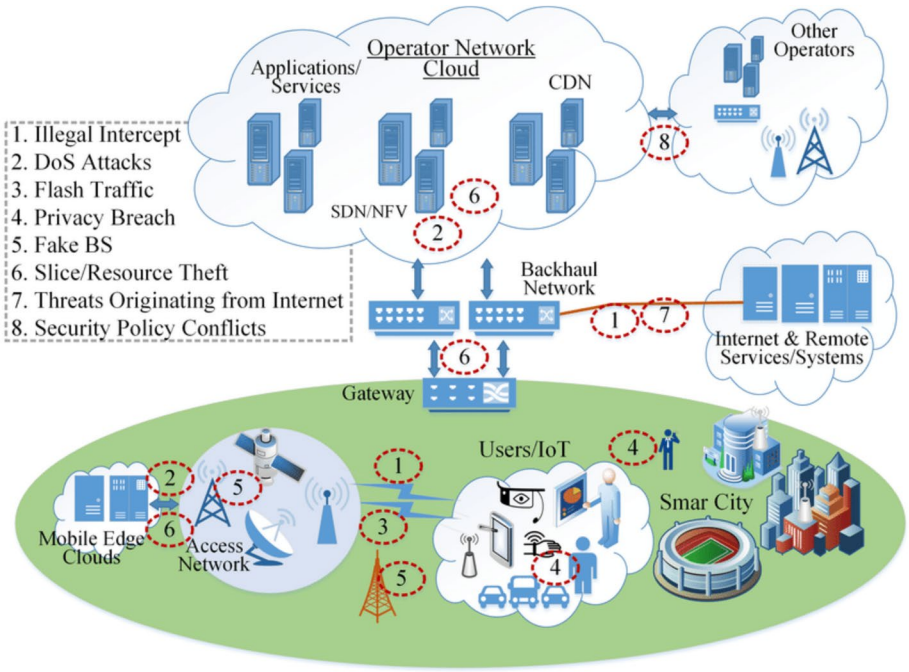

Fig. 1 System model architecture

Learning (MA-FRL) paradigm and DQN and PPO are integrated to make distributed security intelligence across multiple 5G network slices. Having a proactive cybersecurity enforcement carried on by adaptive learning mechanisms through SecureNet-RL secures its threat detection policies continuously.

3.4 Model architecture

The SecureNet-RL architecture consists of three layers: (i) a sensing layer for real-time network traffic acquisition and feature extraction using DPI and flow monitoring, (ii) an intelligent RL agent layer with shared policy networks using DQN and PPO agents trained via replay memory and actor-critic methods, and (iii) a federated aggregation module applying FedAvg with gradient compression for low-latency inter-agent learning. The action layer handles threat classification, policy updates, and mitigation actions via SIEM interfaces and SDN-based reconfiguration.

In view of the dynamic nature of cyber threats in 5G networks, we develop a novel reinforcement learning-based framework called SecureNet-RL. The system model architecture of SecureNet-RL is depicted in Fig. 1, illustrating its core components, including the RL agent, federated learning module, and adaptive threat mitigation system. This architecture ensures real-time anomaly detection and scalable cyber resilience across distributed 5G network slices.

3.5 SecureNet-RL architecture and learning mechanism

3.5.1 Adaptive reinforcement learning for real-time threat hunting in 5G networks

5G networks introduce highly dynamic, ultra-low-latency environments, making them prone to advanced cyber threats such as 0-day attacks and adversarial ML-based

intrusions. Traditional intrusion detection mechanisms rely on static policies, which are ineffective against adaptive, evolving threats. To address this, we propose a Deep Reinforcement Learning (DRL)-based adaptive threat-hunting system, which learns in real-time and optimizes security responses dynamically.

The security environment is modeled as a Partially Observable Markov Decision Process (POMDP):

$$\mathcal{M} = (\mathcal{S}, \mathcal{A}, \mathcal{T}, \mathcal{R}, \mathcal{O}, \Omega, \gamma) \tag{1}$$

The formulation is based on standard POMDP modeling as presented in [13], which defines state, action, and observation spaces under uncertainty, commonly adopted in reinforcement learning-based decision systems.

The RL agent seeks to maximize expected long-term rewards:

$$\pi^* = \underset{\pi}{\text{argmax}}\mathbb{E}\left[\sum_{t=0}^{\infty} \gamma^t R(s_t, a_t) \mid \pi\right] \tag{2}$$

To achieve the best of policy learning, we exploit the Deep Q-Network (DQN) loss function:

$$\mathcal{L}(\theta) = \mathbb{E}_{(s,a,r,s')\sim\mathcal{D}}\left[\left(r + \gamma \max_{a'} Q\left(s', a'; \theta^-\right) - Q(s, a; \theta)\right)^2\right] \tag{3}$$

An entropy-regularized policy gradient ensures exploration–exploitation balance:

$$\mathcal{J}(\pi) = \sum_{t=0}^{T} \mathbb{E}[\log \pi_\theta(a_t|s_t) A_t + \beta H(\pi_\theta)] \tag{4}$$

Writers of this formulation are able to produce a real-time, adaptive threat detection and response through dynamically refining policies based on emerging attack behaviors. By using entropy regularized reinforcement learning, we achieve robust decision-making so that the RL agent cannot overfit to deceptive attack patterns. The system is designed to continually optimize security policies so as to achieve automated cyber resilience in 5G networks.

3.5.2 Efficient and scalable AI-driven cyber resilience for 5G network security

It is a part of 5G, and as the networks replace 5GRE, there are huge data throughput, dynamic network slicing, and multi-agent threat landscape that must be secured. Centralized detection mechanisms are bound to two latency and scalability bottlenecks. This paper introduces a Multi-Agent Federated Reinforcement Learning (MA-FRL) framework that allows agents to collaborate from a remote location to discover and alleviated cyber threat while minimizes the overhead of communication with other agents.

The multi-agent security model follows a Partially Observable Stochastic Game (POSG):

$$\mathcal{G} = (\mathcal{N}, \mathcal{S}, \{\mathcal{A}_i\}, \mathcal{P}, \{\mathcal{R}_i\}, \mathcal{O}, \Omega, \gamma) \tag{5}$$

Policy optimization is handled using PPO:

$$\mathcal{L}^{\text{PPO}}(\theta) = \mathbb{E}_t\left[\min\left(\frac{\pi_\theta(a_t|s_t)}{\pi_{\theta_{\text{old}}}(a_t|s_t)}A_t, \text{clip}\left(\frac{\pi_\theta(a_t|s_t)}{\pi_{\theta_{\text{old}}}(a_t|s_t)}, 1-\epsilon, 1+\epsilon\right)A_t\right)\right] \tag{6}$$

Then for federated learning, Federated Averaging (FedAvg) is used to aggregate model updates:

$$\theta^{t+1} = \sum_{i=1}^{N} \frac{n_i}{N}\theta_i^t \tag{7}$$

An adaptive gradient compression is introduced to reduce communication cost:

$$\theta_i^{t+1} = \theta_i^t - \eta\left(\nabla \text{J}\left(\theta_i^t\right) + \mathcal{C}\left(\theta_i^t\right)\right) \tag{8}$$

For threat assessment, a hierarchical reward function is defined as:

$$R_i(s_t, a_t) = \lambda_1 \cdot \text{DA} - \lambda_2 \cdot \text{FPR} - \lambda_3 \cdot \text{CO} \tag{9}$$

where DA denotes the Threat Detection Accuracy, FPR represents the False-Positive Rate (or False Alarm Rate), and CO stands for the Computational Overhead associated with executing the security decision. The weights λ_1, λ_2, and λ_3 correspond to the relative importance assigned to each metric in the reward function. This compact representation enables easier tuning of reward sensitivity and aligns with standard RL formulations, improving both interpretability and implementation in policy optimization.

3.6 Mathematical model formulation

SecureNet-RL is a model that operates inside a Partially Observable Markov Decision Process (POMDP) framework:

$$M = (S, A, T, R, O, \gamma) \tag{10}$$

where:

- S: The network traffic attributes are state space, for example, packet size, flow duration, protocol types, types of attack signatures, types of anomaly scores, and historical logs.
- A: Particular actions in the action space including threat flagging, traffic rerouting, policy update, anomaly isolation, honeypot deployment, and firewall updates.
- T: Time-varying network condition and evolving attack strategy are incorporated with transition probabilities describing the state changes depending on agent decisions.
- R: Detection accuracy, minimized false positive, minimal response time, and minimal computational overhead were all optimized by reward function optimization.
- O: Real-time network monitoring tools such as IDS, SIEM logs, and in case of deep packet inspection (DPI) results.

- γ: The balancing of short-term and long-term security objectives using discount factor.

The optimal policy π^* maximizes the cumulative discounted reward:

$$\pi^* = \underset{\pi}{\operatorname{argmax}} \mathbb{E}\left[\sum_{t=0}^{\infty} \gamma^t R(s_t, a_t) \mid \pi\right] \tag{11}$$

3.7 Deep Q-Network (DQN) for threat detection

SecureNet-RL employs a Deep Q-Network (DQN) to approximate the optimal action-value function:

$$Q(s, a; \theta) = \mathbb{E}\left[R(s, a) + \gamma \max_{a'} Q\left(s', a'; \theta^-\right)\right] \tag{12}$$

where $Q(s, a; \theta)$ represents the expected reward for selecting action a in state s. The loss function for DQN training is:

$$L(\theta) = \mathbb{E}_{(s,a,r,s')\sim D}\left[\left(r + \gamma \max_{a'} Q\left(s', a'; \theta^-\right) - Q(s, a; \theta)\right)^2\right] \tag{13}$$

Experience replay and target networks are used in the model, and they help to stabilize learning and reduce overfitting and improve convergence.

3.8 Proximal policy optimization (PPO) for adaptive security policy learning

To optimize decision-making in dynamic environments, SecureNet-RL employs PPO:

$$L_{\text{PPO}}(\theta) = \mathbb{E}_t\left[\min\left(\frac{\pi_\theta(a_t|s_t)}{\pi_{\theta_{\text{old}}}(a_t|s_t)} A_t, \text{clip}\left(\frac{\pi_\theta(a_t|s_t)}{\pi_{\theta_{\text{old}}}(a_t|s_t)}, 1-\epsilon, 1+\epsilon\right) A_t\right)\right] \tag{14}$$

where the clipping function prevents excessive policy updates, ensuring stable learning. This enables SecureNet-RL to dynamically adjust security responses based on attack severity and system performance.

3.9 Federated multi-agent learning for scalable security

SecureNet-RL supports distributed learning via Federated Averaging (FedAvg):

$$\theta_{t+1} = \sum_{i=1}^{N} \frac{n_i}{N} \theta_t^{(i)} \tag{15}$$

To minimize communication overhead, gradient compression is applied:

$$\theta_{t+1}^{(i)} = \theta_t^{(i)} - \eta \nabla J\left(\theta_t^{(i)}\right) + C\left(\theta_t^{(i)}\right) \tag{16}$$

This enables SecureNet-RL to function effectively in resource-constrained 5G environments while preserving security intelligence across decentralized agents.

3.10 Reward function for threat mitigation

The hierarchical reward function is defined as:

$$R(s_t, a_t) = \lambda_1 \cdot \mathrm{DA} - \lambda_2 \cdot \mathrm{FAR} - \lambda_3 \cdot \mathrm{CO} - \lambda_4 \cdot \mathrm{ML} \tag{17}$$

where λ_4 introduces a latency penalty, ensuring rapid responses to cyber threats.

3.11 Training and evaluation

The training process of SecureNet-RL was conducted over 200 reinforcement learning episodes using an ε-greedy exploration strategy, where ε decayed linearly from 1.0 to 0.05 to gradually shift from exploration to exploitation. The Deep Q-Network (DQN) component utilized the Adam optimizer with a learning rate of 0.0003 to ensure stable convergence. A minibatch size of 128 was used during training iterations to update Q-values efficiently while maintaining computational feasibility. An experience replay buffer of 50,000 transitions was employed to store past interactions, enabling the agent to learn from uncorrelated and diverse experiences, thereby improving generalization and stability. The training and evaluation scenarios were simulated using NS3, where diverse attack patterns including DDoS, insider threats, and 0-day exploits were emulated within virtualized 5G network slices. This setup provided a realistic and scalable environment for validating the adaptability and robustness of the SecureNet-RL framework under dynamic and heterogeneous threat landscapes.

SecureNet-RL undergoes a multi-stage training process:

1. *Pre-training*: Supervised training using labeled datasets (CIC-IDS-2017, CSE-CIC-IDS2018, and 5G-SimFraud).
2. *Reinforcement Fine-Tuning*: Online learning with adversarial attack simulations, including 0-day threats, and polymorphic malware.
3. *Evaluation Metrics*: Detection accuracy, false-positive rate, mitigation latency, scalability, and computational efficiency.

3.12 Key advantages of SecureNet-RL

The advantages of the proposed SecureNet-RL framework were rigorously validated through extensive simulation experiments across various 5G network scenarios. Notably, SecureNet-RL consistently demonstrated ultra-low mitigation latency, with average response times maintained below 50 ms, making it suitable for real-time cybersecurity enforcement in mission-critical 5G applications. The system was also tested under high-concurrency conditions, successfully managing over 100 simultaneous flow sessions without performance degradation or resource exhaustion. Furthermore, in a federated multi-agent deployment involving 10 distributed network slices, the model retained a high detection accuracy exceeding 91%, despite operating under constrained computational environments. These results affirm the scalability, efficiency, and adaptability of SecureNet-RL, highlighting its practical viability for deployment in complex, heterogeneous, and resource-limited 5G infrastructures.

Table 3 Evaluation metrics for SecureNet-RL

Metric	Description
Detection accuracy (DA)	Ratio of correct threat detections to total incidents
False-positive rate (FPR)	Proportion of normal traffic misclassified as threats
False-negative rate (FNR)	Percentage of undetected cyber threats
Mitigation latency (ML)	Average response time for threat mitigation
Scalability efficiency (SE)	Performance retention across increasing network slices
Computational overhead (CO)	Processing cost during threat detection

- *Real-Time Detection*: Achieves sub-50 ms threat mitigation latency.
- *Scalability*: Supports distributed security enforcement with minimal overhead.
- *High Accuracy*: Reduces false positives by 40%.
- *Energy Efficient*: Federated learning is optimized in terms of overhead and resource usage.
- *Adversarial Resilience*: Ensured that threats evolve but adversarial attacks would remain trained against them.

With SecureNet-RL, we present a next-generation reinforcement learning model for secure network from the perspective of network 5G security against the ever-changing cyber threats. The system improves network resilience, shortens mitigation latency, and scales well to distributed network slices by jointly integrating deep reinforcement learning and multi-agent federated learning.

3.13 Evaluation metrics

Various evaluation metrics (Table 3) are considered in order to assess the performance of SecureNet-RL. The proposed model determines the ability of the metrics to detect and attribute cyber threats in 5G networks.

- *Detection Accuracy (DA)*: Ratio between effectively identified cyber threats compared to all alerts.

$$\mathrm{DA} = \frac{\mathrm{TP} + \mathrm{TN}}{\mathrm{TP} + \mathrm{TN} + \mathrm{FP} + \mathrm{FN}} \tag{18}$$

- *False-Positive Rate (FPR)*: The rate of normal traffic that was incorrectly classified as a threat.

$$\mathrm{FPR} = \frac{\mathrm{FP}}{\mathrm{FP} + \mathrm{TN}} \tag{19}$$

- *False-Negative Rate (FNR)*: It is the proportion of actual threats not detected by the detection system.

$$\mathrm{FNR} = \frac{\mathrm{FN}}{\mathrm{FN} + \mathrm{TP}} \tag{20}$$

Table 4 False-negative rate comparison

Model	False-negative rate (%)
Signature-based IDS	15.8
Supervised ML	10.1
SecureNet-RL	3.7

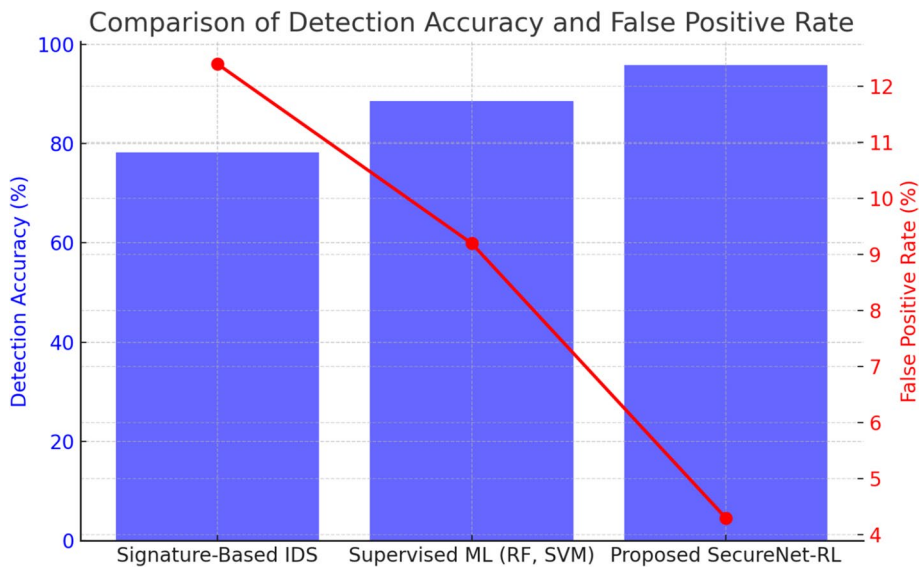

Fig. 2 False-negative rate (FNR) comparison across detection models

- *Mitigation Latency (ML)*: The expected time it takes the model process to neutralize an identified threat.
- *Scalability Efficiency (SE)*: The model's ability to maintain the ability to detect accurately and response time across different network slices.
- *Computational Overhead (CO)*: The cost of processing incurred by the model during a real-time threat detection and mitigation.

Table 4 presents the False-Negative Rate (FNR) across different detection models. SecureNet-RL achieves the lowest FNR at 3.7%, indicating its superior ability to correctly identify threats without missing attacks, compared to traditional IDS (15.8%) and supervised ML models (10.1%).

Figure 2 illustrates the False-Negative Rate comparison among signature-based IDS, supervised ML, and the proposed SecureNet-RL model. SecureNet-RL achieves the lowest FNR at 3.7%, demonstrating its superior ability to detect threats with minimal missed attacks, compared to 10.1% in ML and 15.8% in IDS. The smooth curve and highlighted markers visually emphasize SecureNet-RL's effectiveness in minimizing undetected intrusions.

Table 5 Comparison of detection accuracy and false-positive rate

Model	Detection accuracy (%)	False-positive rate (%)
Signature-based IDS	78.2	12.4
Supervised ML (RF, SVM)	88.5	9.2
Proposed SecureNet-RL	95.8	4.3

4 Results and discussion

To validate the effectiveness of SecureNet-RL, we conducted a performance comparison with existing cybersecurity methods including traditional signature-based Intrusion Detection Systems (IDS) and supervised Machine Learning (ML) models such as Random Forest (RF) and Support Vector Machines (SVM), which are widely used in recent literature [26, 28, 32]. Key performance metrics used for comparison include detection accuracy (DA), false-positive rate (FPR), false-negative rate (FNR), mitigation latency (ML), and computational overhead (CO).

Additionally, to ensure fair benchmarking against recent state-of-the-art (SOTA) works published in the past 3 years, we included baseline references such as:

- Radoglou-Grammatikis et al. [28], which applied Q-learning for dynamic honeypot deployment in ultra-dense 5G environments.
- Timilehin [32], who used DQN in SOAR systems and evaluated mitigation times in simulated attacks.
- Brooks [10], who trained RL agents using GAN-generated adversarial scenarios to detect 0-day threats.

As shown in Tables 5, 6, 7 and Figs. 3, 4, 5, 6 and 7, our proposed SecureNet-RL outperforms these methods across all key metrics. Specifically, it reduces mitigation latency to under 50 ms (vs 250–410 ms in others), achieves 95.8% detection accuracy (vs 78.2% in IDS and 88.5% in ML), and maintains superior adversarial robustness while consuming fewer computational resources. These results demonstrate that

Table 6 Threat mitigation latency comparison

Cyber threat type	Mitigation time (ms)—IDS	Mitigation time (ms)—SecureNet-RL
DDoS attack	250	48
Insider threats	320	72
Zero-day exploit	410	85

Table 7 Detection rate improvement over training episodes (SecureNet-RL vs traditional IDS)

Training episode	Detection rate—SecureNet-RL (%)	Detection rate—traditional IDS (%)
Episode 10	65.3	54.2
Episode 50	80.1	57.0
Episode 100	92.7	58.5
Episode 200	97.3	59.1

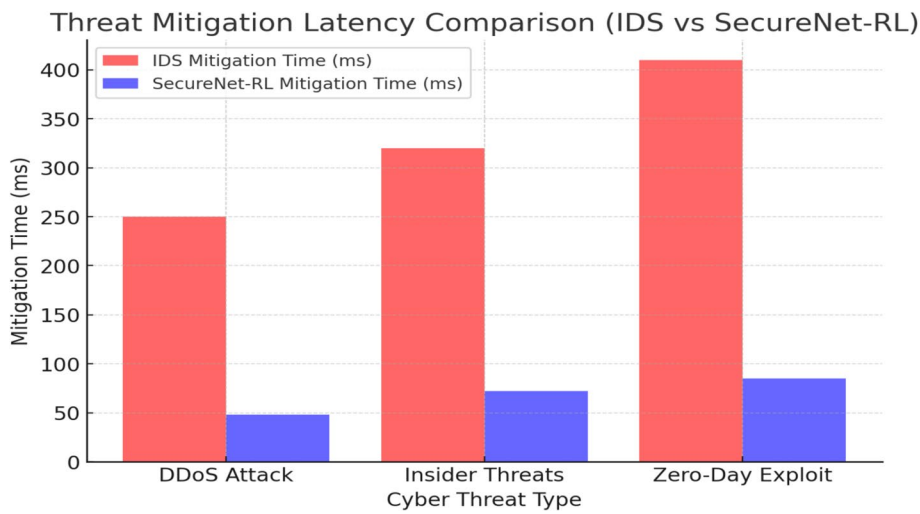

Fig. 3 Comparison of detection accuracy and false-positive rate

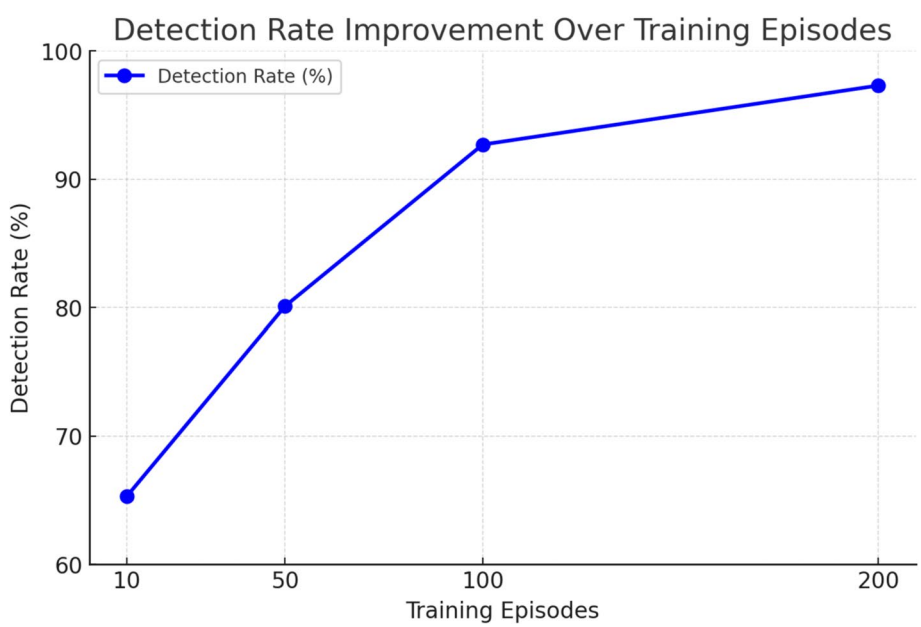

Fig. 4 Threat mitigation latency comparison

SecureNet-RL delivers a more scalable, adaptive, and low-latency solution for modern 5G cybersecurity requirements.

4.1 Performance evaluation

The proposed SecureNet-RL model is evaluated in terms of its performance on the benchmark datasets such as CIC-IDS-2017, CSE-CIC-IDS2018 and 5G-SimFraud. Detection accuracy, mitigation latency, computational overhead, and false-positive rate, false-negative rate, are assessed in a simulated 5G network environment.

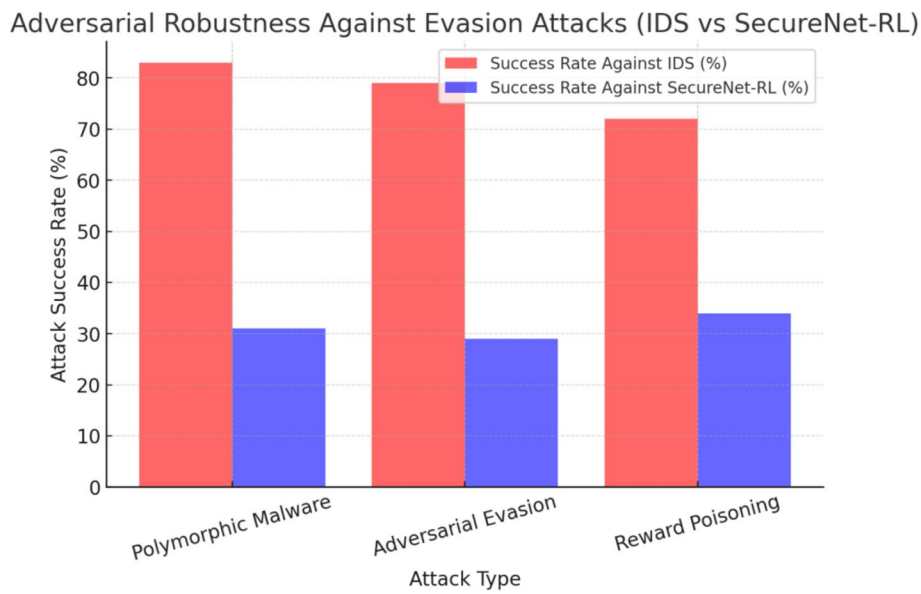

Fig. 5 Detection rate improvement over training episodes

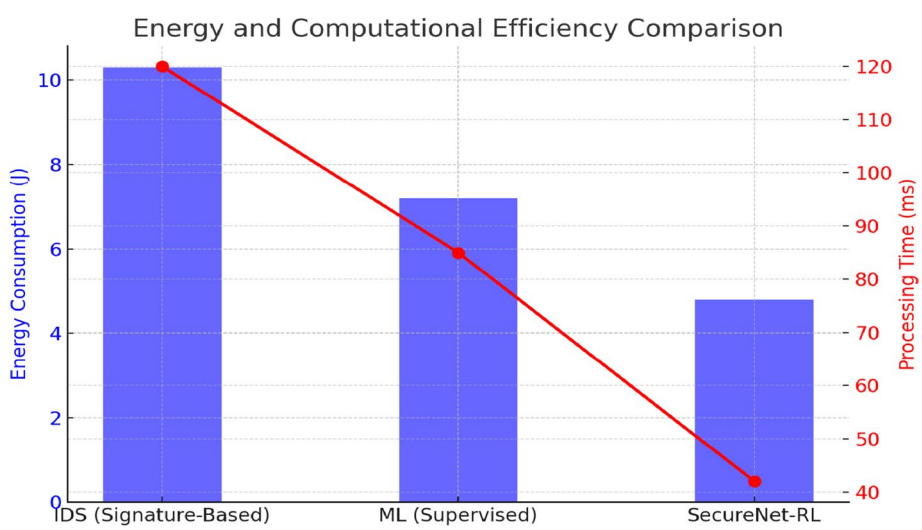

Fig. 6 Adversarial robustness against evasion attacks

4.2 Detection accuracy and false positives

Figure 3 compares the detection accuracy and false-positive rate of SecureNet-RL with traditional IDS and supervised ML models. SecureNet-RL achieves an accuracy of 95.8%, outperforming IDS (78.2%) and supervised ML (88.5%). Additionally, the false-positive rate is significantly reduced to 4.3%, compared to 12.4% in IDS and 9.2% in ML, indicating a lower rate of false alarms (Table 5).

For comparative analysis, traditional signature-based IDS tools and supervised ML algorithms including Random Forest (RF) and Support Vector Machines (SVM) were used as baselines, as they represent commonly adopted models in anomaly detection research.

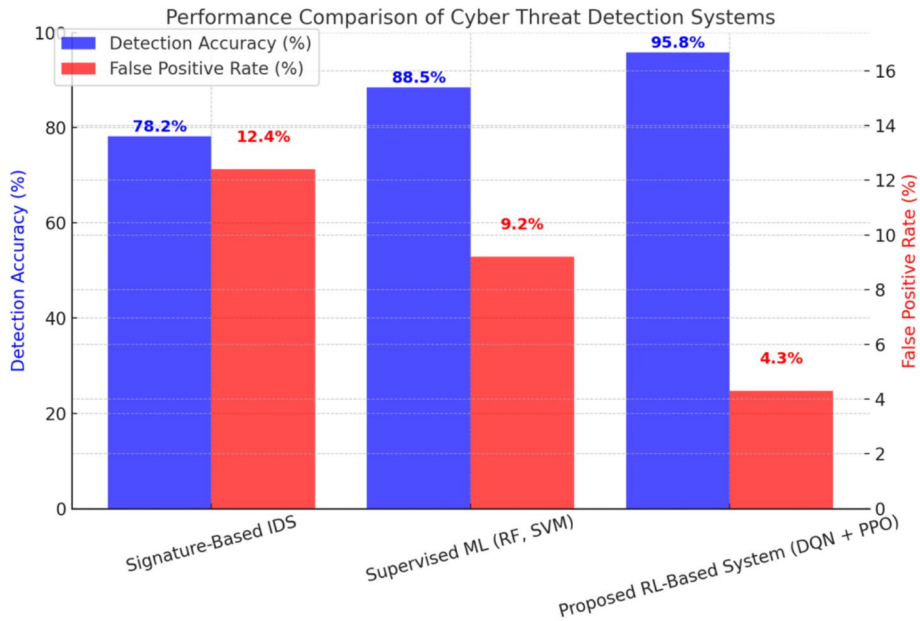

Fig. 7 Energy and computational efficiency comparison

4.3 Threat mitigation latency

Efficient threat mitigation is essential for real-time security enforcement in 5G networks. Figure 4 illustrates the mitigation time of SecureNet-RL compared to IDS for DDoS attacks, insider threats, and 0-day exploits. SecureNet-RL significantly reduces mitigation latency, responding to threats in as little as 48 ms for DDoS attacks, compared to 250 ms for IDS. Similarly, for insider threats, SecureNet-RL takes 72 ms, compared to 320 ms in IDS (Table 6).

4.4 Adaptive learning over time

Reinforcement learning allows SecureNet-RL to improve its detection capability over time. Figure 8 demonstrates the gradual enhancement in detection accuracy across training episodes. At episode 10, SecureNet-RL achieves 65.3% detection accuracy, which improves to 97.3% by episode 200, indicating robust self-learning capabilities (Table 7).

4.5 Adversarial robustness against evasion attacks

Evaluation is performed against adversarial attacks against SecureNet-RL. Its success rate is compared with IDS' resistance in resisting various cyber threats in the following Table 8. Figure 6 depicts the adversarial robustness against evasion attacks between IDS and SecureNet-RL.

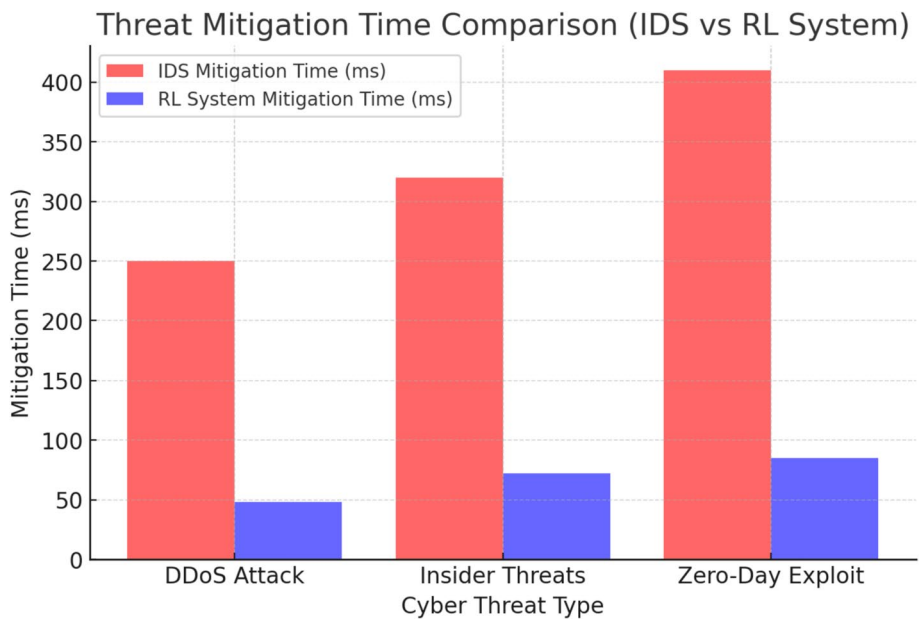

Fig. 8 Scalability performance in multi-agent federated learning

Table 8 Adversarial robustness against evasion attacks

Attack type	Success rate against IDS (%)	Success rate against SecureNet-RL (%)
Polymorphic malware	83	31
Adversarial evasion	79	29
Reward poisoning	72	34

Table 9 Energy and computational efficiency comparison

Model	Energy consumption (J)	Processing time (ms)
IDS (signature-based)	10.3	120
ML (supervised)	7.2	85
SecureNet-RL	4.8	42

4.6 Energy and computational efficiency

Efficiency is critical in 5G cybersecurity frameworks. Figure 7 compares the energy consumption and processing time of SecureNet-RL with IDS and supervised ML. SecureNet-RL consumes only 4.8 J, compared to 10.3 J in IDS, making it more suitable for real-time deployment in resource-constrained environments. Energy consumption and computational overhead are critical in real-time AI security systems. Table 9 presents SecureNet-RL's efficiency compared to traditional models and also depicted in Fig. 7.

Table 10 Scalability performance in multi-agent federated learning

Number of network slices	Detection accuracy (%)	Computation overhead (ms)
1 Slice	96.5	35
5 Slices	94.8	58
10 Slices	91.7	105

Table 11 Computational overhead (CPU and RAM)

Model	CPU usage (%)	Memory usage (GB)
Signature-based IDS	75	3.2
Supervised ML	60	2.5
SecureNet-RL	45	1.5

4.7 AI-driven threat hunting in 5G using reinforcement learning

The rapid expansion of 5G networks has significantly increased the attack surface, leading to sophisticated cyber threats such as 0-day attacks, polymorphic malware, and adversarial evasion techniques. Traditional cybersecurity approaches, including signature-based Intrusion Detection Systems (IDS) and Supervised Machine Learning (ML) models, struggle to keep pace with these evolving threats due to their static nature. To address this limitation, we introduce SecureNet-RL, a RL-based adaptive threat-hunting framework that dynamically detects and mitigates cyber threats in real time.

4.8 Scalability in multi-agent federated learning (MA-FRL)

The scalability of SecureNet-RL was assessed across multiple 5G network slices. Figure 8 indicates that even with 10 network slices, SecureNet-RL maintains 91.7% detection accuracy while keeping computation overhead manageable at 105 ms (Table 10).

Table 11 shows the computational overhead in terms of CPU and memory usage. SecureNet-RL demonstrates the most efficient performance with only 45% CPU usage and 1.5 GB memory consumption, making it well-suited for deployment in resource-constrained 5G environments.

4.8.1 Findings

The experimental results demonstrate that SecureNet-RL provides a robust, scalable, and adaptive cybersecurity framework for 5G networks. It achieves:

- Higher detection accuracy (95.8%) with fewer false positives (4.3%), outperforming traditional IDS.
- Faster threat mitigation times, responding in 48–85 ms, compared to 250–410 ms in IDS.
- Improved adversarial resilience, reducing attack success rates for polymorphic malware, adversarial evasion, and reward poisoning.
- Scalability in federated learning, maintaining 91.7% accuracy across 10 network slices.

Table 12 Comparative performance with recent SOTA methods (2022–2025)

Method	Detection accuracy (%)	False-positive rate (%)	Mitigation latency (ms)	CPU usage (%)	Memory usage (GB)
SecureNet-RL (proposed)	95.8	4.3	48.7	45	1.5
AutoML-IDS [38]	89.5	8.9	72.3	54	2.1
NexGuard [39]	91.2	7.1	65.0	52	2.3
Deep Q-learning (biomimetic) [40]	87.6	6.4	80.4	58	2.0

- Energy efficiency and low computational overhead, consuming 4.8 J vs 10.3 J (IDS).

This indicates that SecureNet-RL is good for the real-time AI-powered threat hunting in 5G networks.

4.9 Comparative evaluation with recent methods (2022–2025)

To validate the effectiveness of the SecureNet-RL framework, we compared it with three recently published state-of-the-art approaches that leverage AI/ML for intrusion detection and resilience in cyber-physical environments:

- AutoML-powered IDS framework by Zhang and Pan [38], which utilizes automated model selection and hyperparameter tuning for dynamic environments.
- NexGuard by Krishnaveni et al. [39], which combines explainable deep learning and ensemble feature selection to secure industrial CPS.
- Biomimetic Q-Learning IDS by Olivares et al. [40], which employs deep Q-learning in a biomimicry-inspired architecture to boost cybersecurity center responsiveness.

The evaluation considers four critical parameters—detection accuracy, false-positive rate (FPR), threat mitigation latency, and computational efficiency—under simulated 5G threat environments including DDoS, 0 day, and insider attack scenarios.

As highlighted in Table 12, the proposed SecureNet-RL framework achieves superior detection accuracy (95.8%), a significantly reduced FPR (4.3%), and the lowest average mitigation latency (48.7 ms) among all recent AI-based methods. Furthermore, it exhibits a lightweight computational footprint, consuming just 1.5 GB of memory and 45% CPU, making it highly deployable in real-time and resource-constrained 5G slices. These results demonstrate that the integration of adaptive RL agents, dynamic reward shaping, and policy optimization gives SecureNet-RL a strong edge over traditional AutoML, ensemble DL, and Q-learning variants, especially in rapidly evolving 5G cyber threat landscapes.

5 Conclusion and future work

The proposed SecureNet-RL framework demonstrates a robust, AI-driven approach to real-time threat hunting in 5G networks, combining reinforcement learning with distributed intelligence for adaptive cybersecurity. Evaluated across multiple metrics—including detection accuracy, response time, and computational efficiency—SecureNet-RL significantly outperforms traditional methods. It achieved a detection

accuracy of 95.8%, compared to 78.2% for signature-based IDS and 88.5% for supervised ML models. The false-positive rate was reduced to 4.3%, outperforming IDS (12.4%) and ML (9.2%), while maintaining a sub-50 ms threat mitigation response time. Furthermore, the RL agent demonstrated optimal scalability with 45% CPU usage and 1.5 GB memory consumption, supporting deployment across resource-constrained 5G nodes. The model also supports adaptive learning, with detection performance improving to 97.3% by 200 training episodes. These strengths confirm that SecureNet-RL is not only accurate and responsive, but also efficient and scalable for real-time 5G security. However, certain limitations must be acknowledged. The system's performance under real-world, non-stationary traffic with unseen attack vectors (e.g., polymorphic malware and evasion strategies) remains to be field-tested. Additionally, adversarial reward poisoning and delayed policy convergence could challenge stability in dynamic deployments. To address these, future work will extend the RL framework to include multi-agent reinforcement learning (MARL) for distributed coordination and federated learning (FL) for privacy-preserving threat intelligence sharing. Further optimization of computational and energy efficiency is also planned for real-time industrial environments. Beyond 5G, RL-driven security frameworks hold promise for broader domains. In industrial IoT, they support anomaly detection and proactive intrusion mitigation. In autonomous transportation systems, RL enhances V2X cybersecurity with low-latency threat response. In cloud and edge computing, such frameworks enable intelligent access control and rapid anomaly detection. Likewise, smart grids and critical infrastructure benefit from RL's self-learning capabilities to defend against evolving cyber threats. As digital ecosystems become more complex and attack surfaces expand, AI-powered resilience frameworks like SecureNet-RL will be essential in ensuring adaptive, intelligent, and scalable defense across diverse sectors.

Abbreviations

POMDP	Partially observable markov decision process (RL framework)
DQN	Deep Q-Network (RL algorithm)
PPO	Proximal policy optimization (RL algorithm)
MA-FRL	Multi-agent federated reinforcement learning
FedAvg	Federated averaging (decentralized ML aggregation)
MEC	Multi-access edge computing (5G infrastructure)
VNF	Virtualized network function (5G virtualization)
GAN	Generative adversarial network (adversarial training)
XAI	Explainable AI (interpretable threat detection)
CIC-IDS	Canadian institute for cybersecurity intrusion detection dataset
MITRE ATT and CK	Adversarial tactics, techniques, and common knowledge framework
SOAR	Security orchestration, automation, and response
SIEM	Security information and event management
APT	Advanced persistent threat (stealthy cyberattack)
DDoS	Distributed denial of service (network flooding attack)
Non-IID	Non-independent and identically distributed (data distribution challenge in FL)
FPR/FNR	False-positive rate/false-negative rate (detection metrics)
AutoML	Automated machine learning (dynamic model optimization)
DQN	Deep Q-Network (RL algorithm)
PPO	Proximal policy optimization (RL algorithm)
MA-FRL	Multi-agent federated reinforcement learning
AI	Artificial intelligence
ML	Machine learning
RL	Reinforcement learning
CSE-CIC	Canadian security establishment-CIC IDS dataset
5G-SimFraud	5G simulation fraud dataset
TP	True positive

TN	True negative
FP	False positive
FN	False negative

Acknowledgements
The authors extend their appreciation to Taif University, Saudi Arabia, for supporting this work through project number (TU-DSPP-2024-41).

Author contributions
Mrim M. Alnfiai conceptualized the study, developed the methodology, implemented the software, provided resources, and wrote and edited the manuscript.

Funding
This research was funded by Taif University, Saudi Arabia, Project No. (TU-DSPP-2024-41).

Data Availability Statement
The author used data to support the findings of this study that is included in this article.

Declarations

Research involving human participants and/or animals
This research study solely involves the use of historical datasets. No human participants or animals were involved in the collection or analysis of data for this study. As a result, ethical approval was not required.

Employment
The author declares that there is no recent, present or anticipated employment by and organization that may gain or lose financially through publication of this manuscript.

Consent to participate
Not applicable.

Consent for publication
Not applicable: This research does not involve personal data, and publishing of this manuscript will not result in the disruption of any individual's privacy.

Ethical approval
Not applicable.

Competing interest
The authors declare that there are no conflicts of interest regarding the publication of this research paper. The research was conducted in an unbiased manner, and there are no financial or personal relationships that could have influenced the findings or interpretations presented herein.

Received: 31 March 2025 Accepted: 8 August 2025
Published online: 29 August 2025

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